



126 |

▲ **A GRAND AFFAIR** Christian Louboutin's India-specific capsule—targeting the \$50-billion Indian wedding market—showcases 10 women's shoe styles, six men's shoe styles and two handbags—in a gradient of metallic hues of platinum, gold and bronze

with his boutique in central Paris, and many personalities were already being photographed wearing shoes designed by the stylish newcomer. But when an early prototype of a silk satin shoe named 'Pensée'—that translates to thought—arrived in the studio from its Italian factory in 1992, the shoe didn't match the image that Louboutin had in mind. "Every time the model turned to reveal the underside of the shoe, it felt sombre." It was then that a flash of inspiration hit him, creating fashion history. Noticing his assistant polishing her nails a vivid, deep red, Louboutin took the nail polish and painted the sole of the shoe on the spot.

Voilà! The famous red soles were born.

T HE ICONIC SHOES have led to a lot of imitation. So, does he think of it as a form of flattery? "I prefer to have an award as a form of flattery, rather than being copied, which is a bigger form of flattery. But it's not my favourite," rues Louboutin. "When my shoes are being copied, they are being done so in a cheap way. There is generally child labour and poor working conditions involved, and that's what upsets me," says Louboutin, who began drawing shoes when he was 10. His obsession with shoes began when he saw a sign showing a typical stiletto with a cross through it in a museum, forbidding visitors from wearing high heels on the parquet floor. But that's a lot of water under the bridge.

Now, Louboutin's collections, derived from influences of various cultures and civilisations, have a global appeal. For instance, in July 2015, he designed the shoes for Indian fashion designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee's annual Mumbai couture show, following it up with a small collection of handbags in October 2016. In 2017, he again collaborated with Mukherjee to launch a limited-edition capsule collection that besides being available in India, travelled to boutiques in Tokyo, London, Paris, Dubai and Shanghai. "Collaborating with